Sara Aref-Zahed ✉ sara.arefzahed@anthro.ox.ac.uk

ACADEMIC POSITION

2023 – 2026	**Research Assistant** o Research Group: Climate, Environmental and Resource Economics o Project Coordination on the EU-project *Land Management for Sustainability* (LAMASUS): developing a governance model based on collaborative work by policy makers, land users, and researchers	Austrian Institute of Economic Research (WIFO), Austria

EDUCATION

2026 – present	**MSc in Medical Anthropology** Focus**:** Environment. Supervisor: Prof. Ann Kelly.	University of Oxford, United Kingdom
2024 – 2026	**MA in Political Science** with honors Final grade: 1.43 (Austrian scale: 1 = best possible grade, 5 = fail). Thesis: *The Birth of Eco-Biopolitics: Bringing More-than-human Life into Governance*. Supervisor: Sergej Seitz, PhD.	University of Vienna, Austria
2023 – 2026	**MSc in Conservation Biology and Biodiversity Management** with honors Final grade: 1.45 (Austrian scale)**.** Thesis: *Dynamics of Reappearance of Nearly Extinct Anurans in a Tropical Region Highly Affected by Amphibian Declines.* Supervisors: Prof. Franz Essl; Carlos Adrían García-Rodríguez, PhD.	University of Vienna, Austria
2016 – 2023	**BA in Political Science** and **BSc in Biology**	University of Vienna, Austria

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed:

Aref-Zahed, S. (forthcoming) 'The Wolf as Political Symbol: Populist Style and Exclusionary Governance in Austria', *Nature and Culture*.

Aref-Zahed, S (under review) 'Eco-Biopolitics and the Governance of More-Than-Human Life: Technocratic and Relational Configurations in the EU and Ecuador', *Environmental Politics.*

Aref-Zahed, S., Essl, F., Zumbado-Ulate, H., Acosta-Chaves, V.J., Chaves Cordero, G.A. & García-Rodríguez, C.A. (in preparation) 'Unexpected Returns: Reappearance Dynamics of Tropical Fogs After Regional Declines', *Diversity and Distribution*.

Editor-reviewed:

Aref-Zahed, S. (in press) 'Sacred Hydrology as Policy: Iranian Traditions of Water Governance', in Mandal, P.K. & Topoonyanont, W.S. (eds) *The Ecospiritual Narratives: Literature, Culture, and Media*. Palgrave Macmillan.

Aref-Zahed, S. (under review) 'Resurrectable Life: An Eco-Biopolitics of De-Extinction and Lazarus Species', in Stark, H. (ed.) *Resurrecting Species: Speculative Engagements with De-Extinction*. Open Humanities Press.

Aref-Zahed, S. (forthcoming) 'Eco-Biopolitics and the Governance of Plant Life in *The Overstory*', in Gürova, E. (ed.) *The Plant Turn: Literature, Ecology, and the Green Imagination across Periods*. Bloomsbury.

Aref-Zahed, S. (forthcoming) 'hamnafas (هم‌نَفَس / co-breather)', in Burke, B. & Fay-Stindt, Z. (eds) *A Lexicon for Animacy*. Publisher to be confirmed.

ACADEMIC SKILLS

Quantitative Methods	Regression (linear, logistic, panel, GLM); causal inference (Difference-in-Differences, quasi-experiments); time series analysis (forecasting); policy trend analysis
Qualitative Methods	Content analysis; document analysis; discourse analysis; semi-structured interviews; case study & comparative case study research
Machine Learning, Modeling & Analysis	Random Forest, Generalized Boosted Models; Generalized Additive Models; ensemble modeling (biomod2); Species Distribution Modeling; multicollinearity analysis; COUE-framework; Niche Margin Index; model evaluation (AUC, TSS, Cohen's Kappa, Boyce)

Programming & Data Analysis	R: Data wrangling; statistical modeling; geospatial analysis; visualization
Geospatial Tools	QGIS

SELECTED CONFERENCE/WORKSHOP TALKS

2026	*Eco-Biopolitics and the Rights of Nature.* Animal Law Student Workshop (virtual).	University of Cambridge, UK
2026	*Eco-Biopolitics: Making Life Count.* Environmental Justice Conference (virtual).	Colorado State University, USA
2026	*Governing Life Beyond the Human: Eco-Biopolitics and the Redistribution of Agency.* Philosophy of Agency in a More-Than-Human World Workshop.	University of Santiago de Compostela, Spain
2026	*Reconfiguration of geographic ranges and climatic niches during the recovery of declined anurans in Costa Rica* (with Héctor Zumbado-Ulate, Víctor Acosta-Chaves, Gerardo Chaves, Franz Essl, & Adrián García-Rodríguez). XIII Latin American Congress of Herpetology. Presented by Adrían García-Rodríguez.	Costa Rica
2025	*Large Predators as Political Symbols: Right-Wing Populism and the Debate over Rewilding in Central and Western Europe.* Rethinking Wild Europe Conference.	University of Vienna, Austria
2025	*Modellierung von Wolfslebensräumen: Naturschutzpotenziale* (Modeling Wolf Habitats: Conservation Potential in Austria). Biodiversity Congress.	BOKU University, Austria
2025	*Assessing the Effectiveness of Price Observation Policies on Food Inflation in Europe: A Difference-in-Differences Approach* (with Franz Sinabell & Anna Renhart). 19th International European Forum on System Dynamics and Innovation in Food Networks. Presented by Franz Sinabell.	Germany

INVITED GUEST LECTURES

2025	*Wolf Habitat Modeling in Austria*. UNESCO Chair: Sustainable Management of Conservation Areas (virtual).	Carinthia University of Applied Science, Austria
2025	*Wolf politics in Austria* in the course *"The Alps: Heights (and Depths) of Modernity"* (taught by Associate Prof. Seth Peabody) (virtual).	Carleton College, USA

SUMMER SCHOOLS

2025	Visegrad Environmental Philosophy Summer School (VEPSS).	University of Wrocław, Poland

GRANTS

2025 Erasmus+ Blended Intensive Program Grant for participation in the VEPSS, 838€.

ORGANIZATION OF WORKSHOPS

2026	LAMASUS: 4th Stakeholder-Board Workshop.	Belgium
2026	Austrian Case-Study Roadshow.	Austria

LANGUAGES

Gilaki: native
Farsi: native
German: native
English: C1 (IELTS Academic, band: 8)
Spanish: approx. A2
Mandarin: approx. A1
Latin: reading knowledge

ACADEMIC & CIVIC ENGAGEMENT

Peer Reviewer: *Genealogy+Critique.*

Board Member: Women Life Freedom Austria (human rights advocacy in Iran).